PRE-FLIGHT PROTOCOL

# 72-Hour Pre-Departure Readiness Checklist

Print this sheet or check items off on your tablet before heading to the airport. Completing Phase 1 and Phase 2 at home while you still have your home cellular SMS signal prevents 99% of arrival headaches.

## // PHASE 1: T-14 TO T-7 DAYS BEFORE FLIGHT (ACCOUNTS & IDENTITY)

- [ ] **Verify Passport Validity & Visa-Free Rules:** Ensure at least 6 months validity and 2 blank visa pages. If using the 30-Day Visa-Free entry or 240-Hour Visa-Free Transit, print your confirmed return/onward flight ticket and hotel bookings.
- [ ] **Download & Bind Alipay (Primary Payment):** Register with your home mobile number, bind TWO credit cards (preferably 1 Visa + 1 Mastercard with $0 foreign transaction fees), and upload your passport scan under *Account → Identity Information*.
- [ ] **Download & Bind WeChat Pay (Secondary Payment):** Register WeChat, enable WeChat Pay under *Me → Pay and Services*, complete passport verification, link both cards, and memorize your 6-digit Payment PIN.
- [ ] **Notify Your Home Bank of China Travel:** Log into your banking app or call support so their fraud system doesn't block sudden charges from "Alipay Singapore / Shanghai" on Day 1.
- [ ] **Set Up Railway 12306 or Trip.com Account:** Register your passport on 12306 (remember the MRZ name rule: omit middle names if verification stalls) or save all passenger passports inside the **Trip.com** app to pre-reserve bullet trains.
- [ ] **Reserve 7-Day Advance Major Attractions:** Set an alarm for 20:00 Beijing Time 7 days prior for the Forbidden City, Terracotta Warriors, or National Museum (or prepare your physical passport for the Forbidden City Foreign Guest Walk-Up window).

## // PHASE 2: T-72 TO T-24 HOURS BEFORE FLIGHT (CONNECTIVITY & APPS)

- [ ] **Install Your China Mainland Roaming eSIM:** Purchase and install a roaming eSIM (Trip.com China eSIM, Airalo, or Nomad) on your unlocked phone. Label the cellular line `"China eSIM"` so it is ready to toggle on upon landing.
- [ ] **Install Hotel Wi-Fi Backup VPN:** Download and log into **LetsVPN** or **Astrill VPN** on both your phone and laptop BEFORE leaving home (VPN download sites are blocked inside China!).
- [ ] **Configure Navigation Apps:** Download **Amap (高德地图)** and switch its language to English (*Settings → General → Language → English*). If on iPhone, verify Apple Maps is installed.
- [ ] **Download Offline Translation Packs:** Open **Google Translate**, **Microsoft Translator**, and **Pleco**, and download the **Offline Chinese (Simplified)** text and camera translation packages.
- [ ] **Inspect Your Power Bank (3C & Wh Check!):** Verify your portable battery bank is ≤100Wh (20,000mAh) AND that the printed capacity text + **3C certification mark** have not rubbed off (otherwise Chinese airport/train security will confiscate it).

## // PHASE 3: FINAL PACKING & OFFLINE PHONE ALBUM PREP

- [ ] **Save First Hotel Name & Address in Chinese Characters:** Take a screenshot of your hotel's Chinese name, street address, and front-desk phone number in a dedicated "China Survival" photo album on your phone.
- [ ] **Save the 12 Emergency Bilingual Flashcards Offline:** Keep China_Emergency_Flashcards_2026.pdf (and screenshots of any allergy/dietary cards or the Hotel PSB Law card) accessible offline on your phone.
- [ ] **Pack Pocket Tissues & Hand Sanitizer:** Pack at least 4–6 travel packs of pocket tissues and wet wipes in your daypack (public restrooms rarely provide toilet paper or soap).
- [ ] **Pack Essential Western OTC Medications:** Pack Imodium/Loperamide, Ibuprofen, Pepto/antacids, antihistamines, and cold medicine in original blister packs.
- [ ] **Power Plugs Check:** China uses 220V. Two-prong flat US/Japanese plugs fit directly into Chinese wall sockets; 3-prong grounded plugs fit Australian-style angled sockets (bring 1 universal adapter for UK/EU plugs).

## // PHASE 4: UPON LANDING AT CHINESE AIRPORT (FIRST 45 MINUTES)

- [ ] **Activate Roaming eSIM While Taxiing:** Switch cellular data to your China eSIM and toggle **Data Roaming = ON**. Confirm Google, WhatsApp, and Alipay connect.
- [ ] **Complete Fingerprints & Arrival Card:** Scan fingerprints at the automated biometric kiosks (if prompted) and present your passport + arrival card at the Foreigners immigration lane.
- [ ] **Perform the "3 RMB Water Test" at Airport 7-Eleven / FamilyMart:** Buy a drink or pack of tissues using Alipay's "Pay" QR code to verify your linked credit card processes smoothly.
- [ ] **Prepare Your 200 RMB Small-Bill Emergency Envelope:** Withdraw 200–300 RMB at an airport bank ATM and break one 100 RMB note into 10 RMB and 20 RMB bills for small P2P vendors.
- [ ] **Enable Alipay Metro Transit QR or Order DiDi:** Open Alipay → *Transport* to activate the city Metro QR pass, or open the Alipay *DiDi* mini-program and walk to the official **Ride-Hailing Pickup Zone (网约车上车点)**—ignore all terminal touts offering "cheap taxis"!

### 📌 EMERGENCY QUICK-REFERENCE CARD (CUT OR SCREENSHOT)

- **Police (English Dispatch):** 110
- **Ambulance Emergency:** 120
- **24/7 Tourist & Hotel Mediation:** 12345
- **Immigration & Visa Hotline:** 12367
- **Alipay International Support:** +86-571-95188
- **Railway 12306 English Line:** 12306
- **Fee Rule:** Split bills >200 RMB to avoid 3% fee
- **Train Gates:** Always use Manual Gate (人工通道)